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Grade	1	Word Count	243
Lexile	480L	Multi-level	H N S
Learning A–Z	level H		

Refer to the Focus Question on page 2 of this title to guide discussion and support additional learning connected to the text.

A monarch butterfly changes from egg to caterpillar, then to pupa, and finally to butterfly in **The Butterfly Life Cycle**. Vivid photographs illustrate this process.

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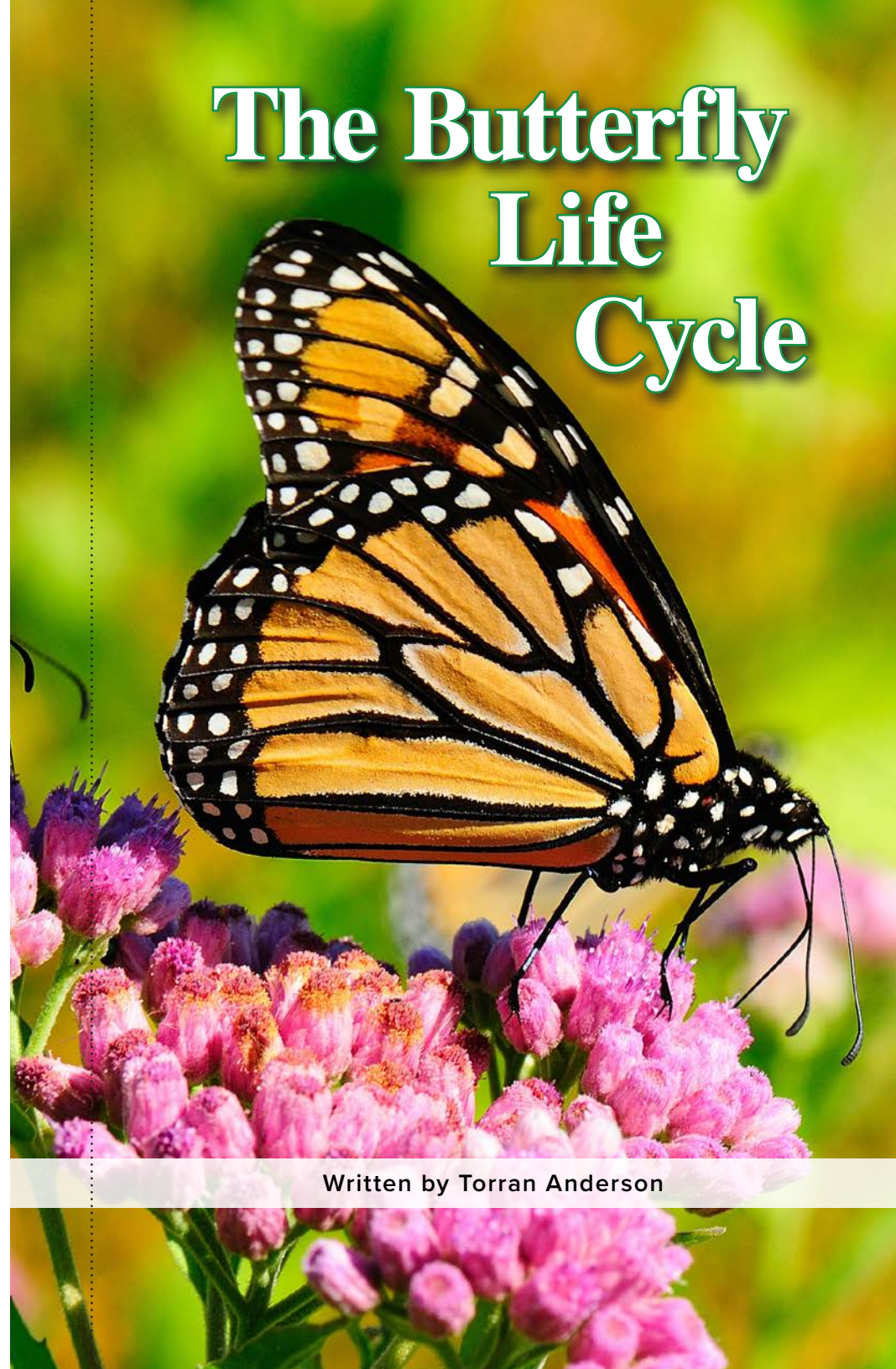
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The Butterfly Life Cycle



Written by Torran Anderson

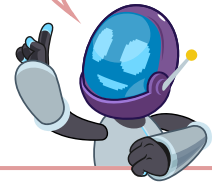
The Butterfly Life Cycle



Written by Torran Anderson

Focus Question

What is the life cycle of a monarch butterfly?



Words to Know

butterfly	mate
caterpillar	pupa
life cycle	stages

Connections

Writing and Art

Draw a diagram of the butterfly life cycle. Write about each stage and what happens in between the stages.

Science

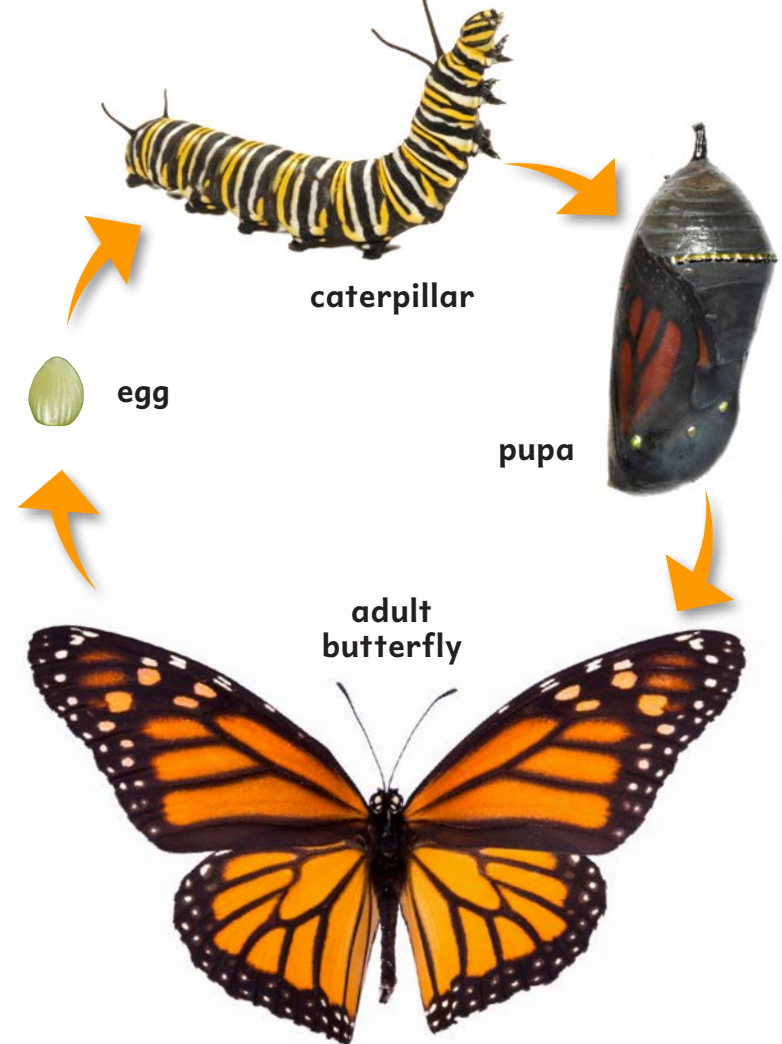
Pick two stages of the butterfly life cycle. Compare and contrast them with a partner.



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Life Cycle of a Butterfly



The Life Cycle

A monarch **butterfly** has four **stages** in its **life cycle**.



A young caterpillar hatches from its egg. A female monarch butterfly usually only lays one egg on a leaf.

Egg

A female monarch butterfly lays an egg on a leaf.

A **caterpillar** grows inside the tiny egg. The egg hatches in three to twelve days.



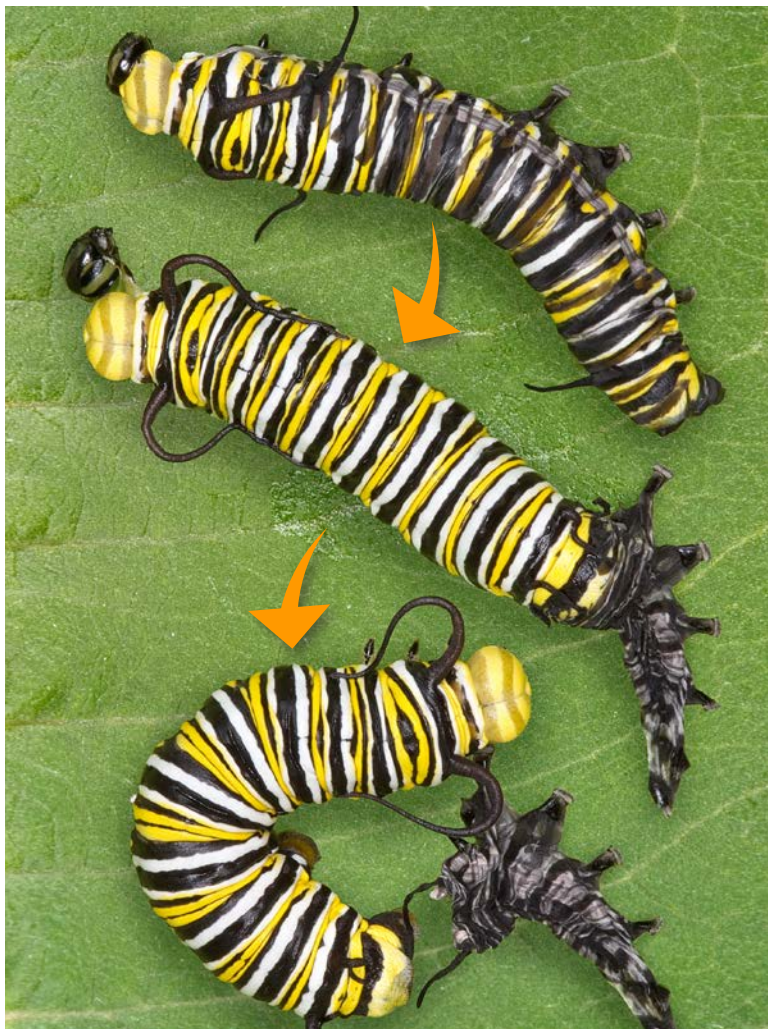
The young caterpillar eats its own shell. If there are two eggs on a leaf, the caterpillar will eat the other egg first!

The hungry caterpillar eats all the time.

First, the caterpillar eats its own eggshell.

Then, the caterpillar eats the leaf it is on.





The caterpillar puts down sticky silk. The silk keeps the old skin in place while the caterpillar wiggles out of it.

The caterpillar grows quickly.
Its skin does not grow.
The caterpillar's skin splits
and peels away.



Do You Know?

Monarch caterpillars
only eat the leaves of the
milkweed plant.

The caterpillar's bright black and yellow colors warn animals that they will get sick if they eat it.

New skin is under the old skin.

The caterpillar sheds its skin
four to six times.

The caterpillar grows
for two to four weeks.





The caterpillar's skin splits down its back like a zipper!

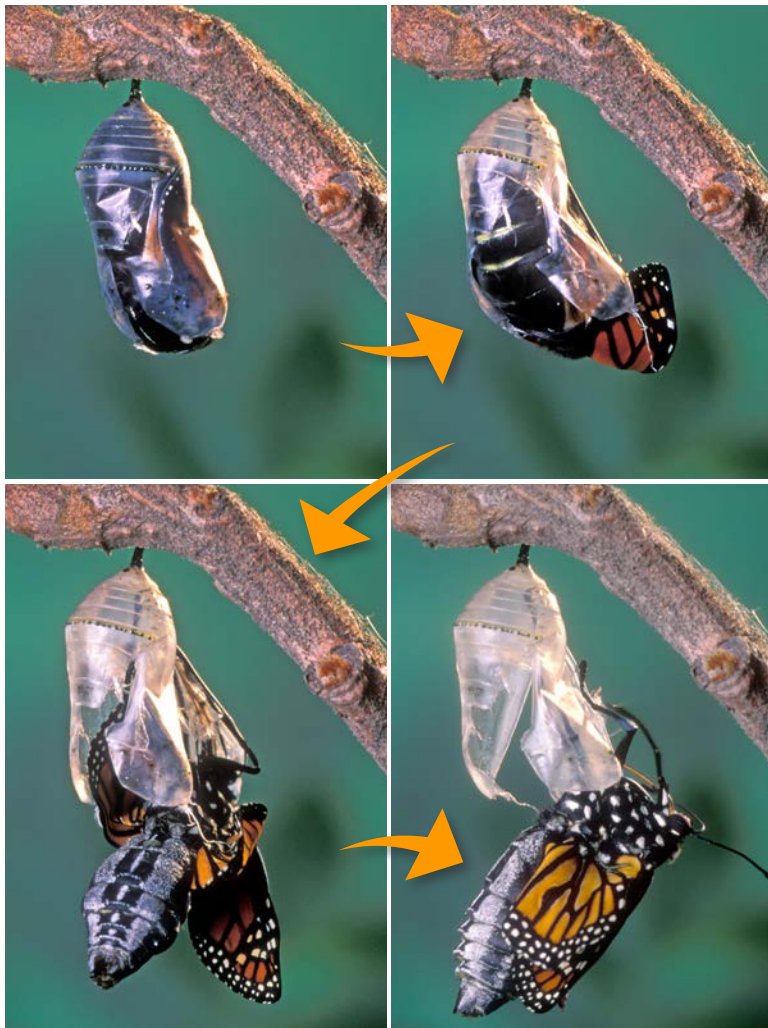
Pupa

When the caterpillar is grown,
it hangs from a branch.
It sheds its skin one last time.
The new skin is bright green.



The green pupa looks like a leaf. The color helps it hide from other animals.

This green skin becomes hard.
The caterpillar is now a **pupa**.
It will stay inside its shell for
one to two weeks.



The butterfly breathes in air to make its body bigger. Then, the shell splits so the butterfly can climb out.

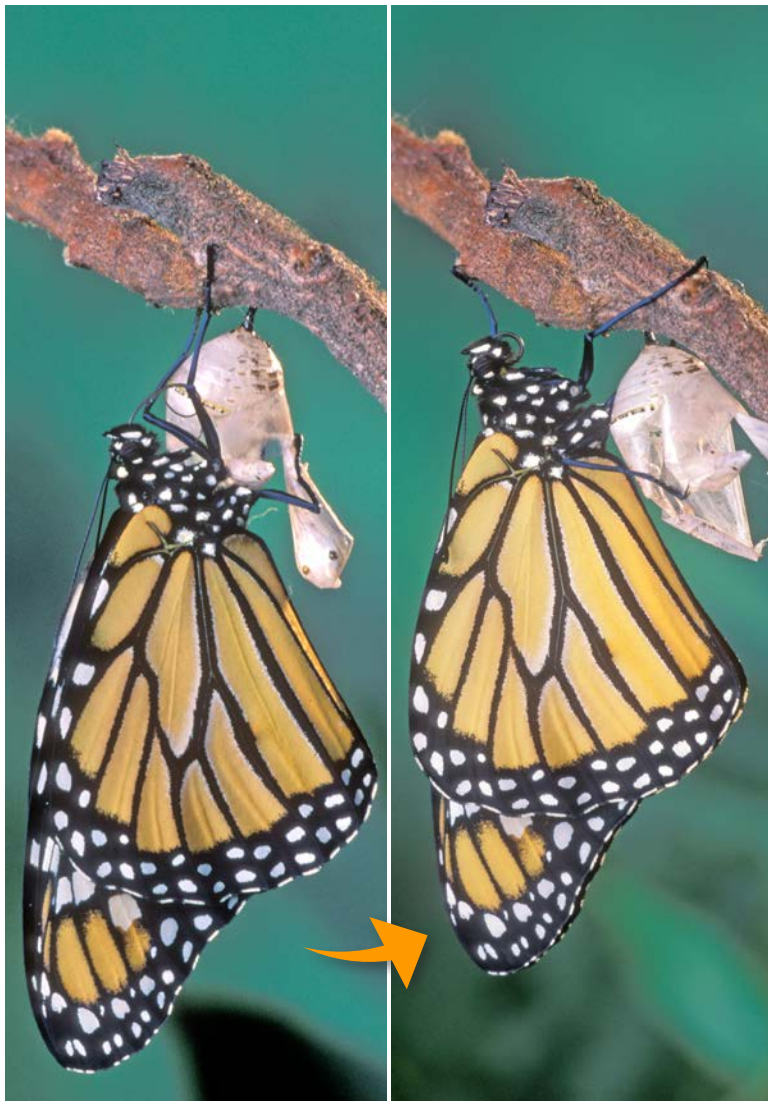
Adult Butterfly

The pupa comes out of its shell.
It is now a butterfly.
Its wings are wet.



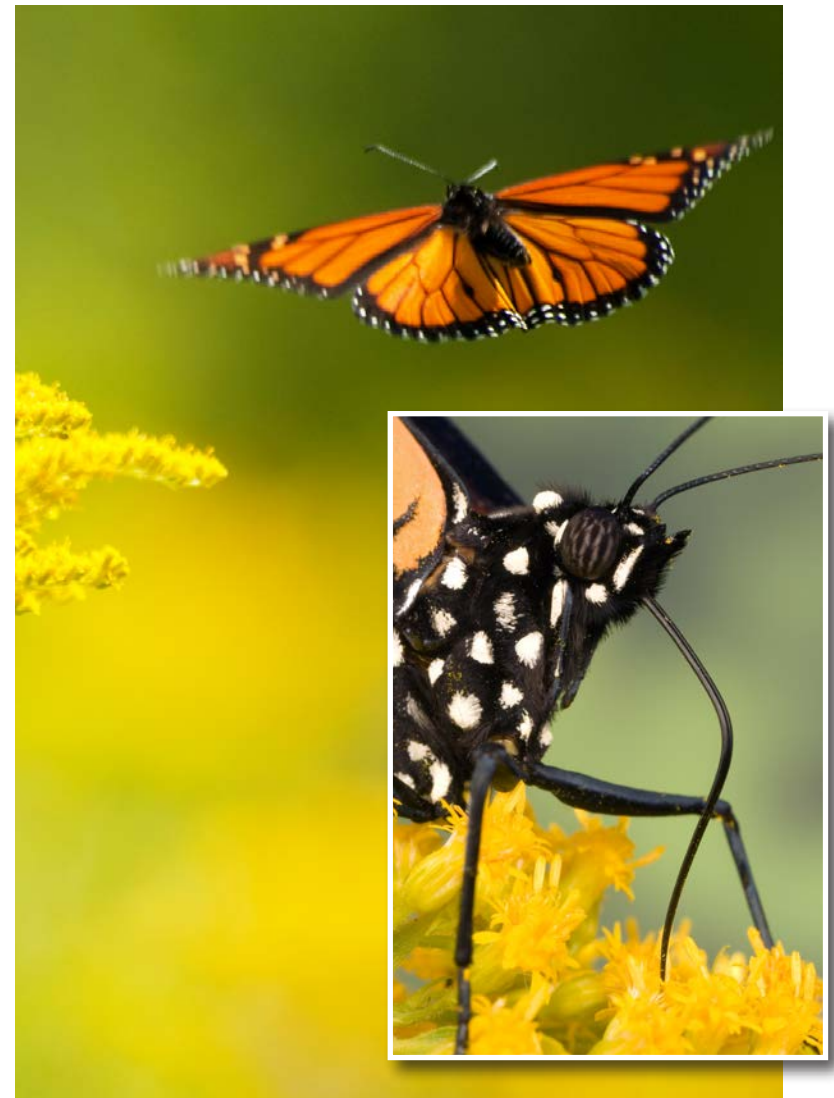
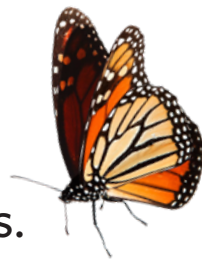
While the butterfly hangs, it pushes liquid into its wings to make them unfold.

The new butterfly rests.
The butterfly must hang upside down, or it will not be able to fly.



Most monarch butterfly wings are about 4 inches (10 cm) from tip to tip.

The butterfly hangs for three to four hours. The sun and air dry its wings.



Monarch butterflies drink nectar, a sweet liquid made by plants. They sip nectar with a long tongue shaped like a tube.

Then, the butterfly is able to fly. It flies off to eat. It also searches for a **mate**.





A female monarch butterfly may lay 400 to 500 eggs in her lifetime!

A monarch butterfly may only live for two to six weeks.
The female monarch lays her eggs.
The butterfly life cycle starts again.

Glossary

butterfly (*n.*) page 4

an insect with four wings that are bright in color

caterpillar (*n.*) page 5

the young form of a butterfly or moth

life cycle (*n.*) page 4

the stages of change that a living thing goes through during its life

mate (*n.*) page 14

the partner of an animal

pupa (*n.*) page 10

a young insect before it becomes an adult

stages (*n.*) page 4

periods of time in the growth of something, such as insects